

Which Voice Will You Listen To? — Graham Weaver

Stanford GSB Class of 2024 · Graduation Speech · 24 min

To live at full power, you must silence your voice of fear and follow your inner truth through three promises: remove what keeps you stuck, pursue what energizes you, and commit fully now.

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The Two Voices

- We all have two competing internal forces: the survival instinct (voice of fear, doubt, anxiety, inner critic) that's loud and in your head, and your inner truth (intuition, soul, true self) that's quieter and shows up in your body—heart, gut, chest
- The voice of fear leads to a life that's too small. You already know this because you feel the dissonance and tension when doing something beneath you
- Your second voice contains your dreams, your path, your energy. When you stop denying who you really are, there's no limit to what you can accomplish
- Energy is the language of your soul—it doesn't use words, it uses your whole body to show you what excites you

The meaning of life is to live your life at full power. That power is already inside you, accessed through your second voice.

Promise 2: Follow Your Energy

- 'Follow your passion' is harmful advice—it implies you have one passion, should know it at 28, do it for 40 years, and know how to follow it. None of this is true. Not one of 500+ entrepreneurs Weaver invested in followed that path
- Instead, follow your energy—whatever gives you energy right now. Do the Nine Lives exercise: Life 1 is your current path. Lives 2-9 must start today and be things you're so excited about you'd jump out of bed to do them
- Ask yourself: 'Of all nine lives, what would I do if I knew I wouldn't fail?' That's your most dear dream—the path you want to be on at some point
- Pull something from those other lives into your current life to make your energy infectious. The human soul needs something to hope for

Energy Is Abundant

- Energy is not an exhaustible resource like willpower or endurance. Energy is abundant, like love—the more you tap into it, the more you have. The more you give away, the more you get back
- You are the person who earned your seat. Your drive, motivation, persistence, and character transfer to your next journey. You get to bring you
- You excited about something, going all in, as long as it takes is not just enough—it's the most powerful force there is. This is all you need
- Weaver started his firm at 25 and began teaching at 29 with no other skills than this formula. After 22 years of teaching, he has more energy now than when he started

Class of 2024, which voice will you listen to?

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Promise 1: Take the Nail Out of Your Head

- Most of us walk around with an obvious problem we refuse to address—a 'nail in our head.' It falls into four categories: bad habits, unresolved past experiences, limiting rules/assumptions, or paralyzing fear
- We don't remove the nail for two reasons: (1) we haven't admitted we have the problem—you must speak your truth out loud, and (2) life will get worse first before it gets better
- Everything you want is on the other side of worse first. Everything you want is on the other side of what you currently fear. The thing you fear is where your work is right now
- We build helmets around our nails instead of removing them—protective systems that consume energy and keep us stuck

Until one is committed, there's always hesitancy, the chance to draw back, always ineffectiveness. — Goethe

Promise 3: Go All In Now

- The biggest trap is being hedged—one foot in, one foot out, waiting for the perfect moment. Most people spend their lives here, never fully committing. This is a huge waste of energy
- The two most dangerous words: 'Not now.' Your inner critic doesn't say give up—it says wait until you're ready, have more experience, everything's perfect. This is just fear in another form
- 'I'll start living when...' (loans paid, more experience, confidence, kids grown, etc.) always leads to a new condition. 'Not now' turns into 'never'
- You with energy, all in, as long as it takes is enough. You don't need anything else. When you go all in, your identity shifts, the conflict dissipates, and the voice of fear lays down its sword

Burnout doesn't come from doing something for a long time. It comes from friction, stress, and tension—from being out of alignment.

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